

POSITION OR BE POSITIONED

THE EKRAM METHOD

Positioning to win
in the AI era

Compiled by Somo

INEVITABLE

INVISIBLE

A FIELD MANUAL



The Ekram Method

*A field manual for making frontier technology
understood, wanted, and believed.*



"position, or be positioned."

Ekram, 2017. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/888465119717408768>

Independent reconstruction from public work. Arranged by Somo.

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Preface

AI made building cheap. It made being understood expensive. For the first time, a single founder can ship what once took a team of fifty. I know because I am doing it, and so is everyone around me. Every barrier that falls lets in a thousand more builders, and the tools that made you fast made everyone fast. Millions of new products are coming, many of them good, built by founders who executed well. Most will disappear without ever being misunderstood, because they were never understood in the first place. That is the trade the AI era made on your behalf. Execution used to be the scarce edge. Now the scarce edge is meaning: whether a market can say what you are, want it, and believe it is where the world is going. Positioning stopped being a marketing tactic layered on at the end and became the strategic foundation that decides how a company is understood from day one. When I became a founder, I felt this directly. Growth tactics were not enough. Posting was not enough. I needed to understand, from first principles, why some ideas capture a market's imagination while others vanish. The clearest thinking I ever found on that question came from Ekram. He had already mapped the perception layer: how positions form, how categories get claimed, how belief compounds into inevitability. But his map reached me scattered, a four-word tweet here, a keynote there, essays, interviews, replies. Fragments are hard to learn from and easy to lose, and nobody had brought them together. This book is my attempt. I collected the public record, verified every line, and arranged it into the method I wish someone had handed me on day one. The words in the gray bands are his. The arrangement, and any mistakes in it, are mine. One thing this book is not: a book for Ekram's audience. His work

grew out of crypto, the market where perception moves fastest and getting it wrong is fatal soonest. The method travels. If you are building in the AI era, this map was drawn under harsher weather than yours, and it reads like it was drawn for you. If you can build, and soon everyone can, this is the discipline that decides whether what you build matters. Somo, 2026

Reading Key

Five kinds of text, never blended.

- **Exact words.** Verbatim tweets and blog captures, in quotation marks, with a source line and a URL. Wording is exact. Punctuation is normalized to plain ASCII, straight quotes, no em dashes. Where the book quotes part of a longer post, the source line says (segment); the link always opens the full post, so the complete context is one tap away.
- **Edited transcript excerpt.** Lines spoken in a talk, lightly cleaned for reading. Labeled as such, set without quotation marks, and never treated as verbatim unless the wording is confirmed unchanged.
- **Synthesis.** The book's framing and method language, in the arranger's voice. Never put in Ekram's mouth.
- **Inherited.** The canon he builds on: Ries and Trout, Cunningham, Thiel, Bezos, Drucker, Sacks.
- **Case.** Public events, public facts, with the reading labeled as ours. The gray bands throughout this book carry only the first two kinds: his exact words, or his labeled transcript lines. Skim the bands and you are reading Ekram, nobody else. One case, in Chapter 2, is drawn from outside his corpus; an editor's note there says so.

Notes On This Book

Not authorized. Not a biography. Ekram has not blessed it. A method reconstructed from public work and arranged by someone who wanted it in one place. The contract:

- Ekram is the source of the method, not the object of worship.
- A line in quotation marks with his name has a receipt: a tweet URL or a blog essay. A line spoken in a talk is labeled an edited transcript excerpt and never dressed as verbatim.
- Interpretation stays separate from source. The reading key holds throughout.
- Third-party summaries of his talks are context only, never his voice, even when they are accurate. Every quote carries a year and a link. Where the record has a gap, the book marks it rather than paving over it. Two labels appear before the back matter explains them, so here they are now. Tier 1 means Ekram spoke about a case on the record; Tier 2 means a public market moment with the reading labeled as ours. A quote marked segment is a verbatim portion of a longer post, cut only at sentence boundaries.

Source Map

What the book is built from. Naming the sources is part of earning trust. The buckets: Ekram's blog essays and Notes at ekram.xyz; his X posts and replies, held in a verbatim quote bank with dates and tweet IDs; his positioning keynote and the Blockworks Empire interview, used as edited transcript; public company reactions, used as cases; the lineage canon. Full receipts live in the back matter: every quote's link in the selected quote bank, the canon behind the method in the lineage map, and who owns each term in the glossary.

How To Read This Field Manual

The map in one line, five movements: meaning, category, belief, inevitability, delivery. Then three passes, and three paths. The passes. Skim the gray bands: Ekram's argument in his own words, about twelve minutes. Study the cases: proof, including where the method failed. Run the methods when you are naming, launching, fundraising, competing, or in a crisis. The paths, for readers who refuse to read in order:

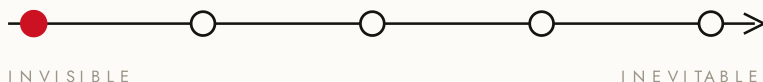
- The spine. Chapters 1, 2, 4, 6, 12, 16. The whole argument in one sitting.
- The build. Chapters 3, 5, 7, 9, 10, 11. Positioning a company from scratch, in dependency order.
- Under fire. Chapter 8 when a competitor is winning, 13 when nobody feels the urgency, 14 before a launch, 15 when attention turns hostile. The toolkits in the back are indexed the same way.

PART I

Meaning

What are you, and why should the market understand you?

Meaning is the floor. Before a market can want you or believe you, it has to file you. This movement is the rational anchor: decide what you are, refuse what you are not, and compress it into something the market can carry. Miss it and nothing above stands. A vivid brand on a confused position only makes the confusion louder.



1

POSITION OR BE POSITIONED

"position, or be positioned."

Ekram, 2017. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/888465119717408768>

Four words, posted in 2017, years before the essays and the keynotes. Everything else in this book is that sentence paying its costs. A position is the place you occupy in someone else's mind. You do not fully control it, and you cannot opt out of having one. The market files you the moment it notices you, using the nearest cached label, and whoever wrote that label owns your first impression. Ekram's essays return to this without mercy:

"the act of positioning happens whether we like it or not. Competitors slander us. Partners invent our script. Even customers have the potential of spreading narratives that are disadvantageous to us."

Ekram, essay "Anchor the market," ekram.xyz, 2022.

Notice who does the positioning in those three sentences. Competitors. Partners. Customers. Everyone except you. The sentence about your company is getting written today, by people who owe you no effort and will not check their work. In the keynote he collapses it to a fork with no third option:

If you do not position, you will be positioned. If you don't choose a category, you will be assigned a category.

Ekram, positioning keynote. Edited transcript excerpt.

Watch it happen to a well-funded thesis. Worldcoin arrived with a serious claim: proof of personhood for the age of AI, a way to tell humans from machines online. The public conversation never filed the thesis. It filed the orb. An iris-scanning sphere is a more vivid sentence than a personhood protocol, so the image did the positioning, the privacy question rode along with it, and governments in several countries paused the project or opened investigations. Ekram was skeptical of the self-description the project led with:

"Idk about this 'verified humans.'"

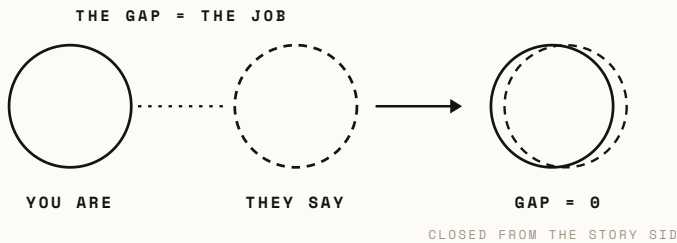
Ekram, 2025. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1917795103994761670>

The lesson is uncomfortable precisely because Worldcoin had done the hard part. The technology was real. The thesis was coherent. And the market's lazy sentence beat both to the filing cabinet. (The Worldcoin reading is ours, a Tier 2 case; his line above is the extent of what he said.) So the first exercise in the method is an act of humility. Before you write the position you want, write the one you will get by default. Say the lazy sentence out loud, the one a distracted stranger would produce four seconds after seeing your homepage. If you can live with that sentence, you may not need to fight. If you cannot, you now know exactly which perception you are trying to overwrite, and every chapter that follows is a tool for overwriting it. If you do not position yourself, you have still been positioned. You just did not get a say.

2

EVERY COMPANY EXISTS TWICE

THE GAP IS THE JOB · ZERO GAP FIG. 01 · CH 2



TWO SENTENCES SIT APART; THE WHOLE JOB IS
CLOSING THE GAP, FROM THE STORY SIDE.

"Every company exists twice: once as reality, and once as the story people tell about it"

Ekram, 2026. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2067652948206010490>

August 2020. A team copied Uniswap almost line for line, named the copy SushiSwap, and ran a vampire attack to drain its liquidity. For a few weeks it worked; more than a billion dollars of liquidity migrated. Code, incentives, interface: all successfully forked. Then the market chose. Uniswap stayed the default, the name people reached for, the standard other projects compared themselves against. The fork kept the code and lost the argument. Ekram's four-word law explains the outcome:

"You can't fork brand."

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1870995210161029238>

What happened is the doctrine of this chapter. Every company exists twice. Once as reality: the code, the team, the treasury, the thing itself. Once as story: what the market believes the thing is. SushiSwap forked the first existence perfectly and could not touch the second, because the second lives in other people's heads, and heads do not accept pull requests. Capital, talent, and press never see your reality. They see the story, and they act on the story. An investor funds the story. A hire joins the story. A journalist repeats the story. The reality determines whether they stay, but the story determines whether they arrive. Control the second existence or it controls the first. Counter-case: General Magic. (Tier 2, editor case.) The opposite failure is a real product whose story never forms. In 1994 a team spun out of Apple shipped the future: a pocket device for messages, calls, and commerce over a network, built by people who would go on to create the iPod, the iPhone's core, Android, and eBay. The engineering was real and the vision was right, thirteen years early. What never arrived was the sentence. A phone that was also a computer had no file to live in, "personal communicator" named a category nobody was carrying, and the market that met the device could not say what it was or why now. It sold almost nothing and faded within a few years. The polite history says too early. The sharper reading is that too early is what a market calls a future nobody made legible: when the same idea returned in 2007, it arrived as three words everyone already understood, a phone, an iPod, an internet communicator, and it swallowed the world. Same future. Different sentence. Invisibility, the failure state of good engineering with no author.

The working move: write what the company is in one sentence. Write what the market says it is in one sentence. The gap between those two sentences is the whole job, and the rest of this book is a method for closing it from the story side. The market never meets your product. It meets the story of your product, and it decides before it checks.

Source. Uniswap and SushiSwap (2020) and General Magic (1994-2002) are public record; both readings are ours. General Magic appears nowhere in Ekram's corpus, as the note above says. The 2007 three-words framing is Steve Jobs's, from the iPhone introduction, paraphrased.

3

POSITION FIRST, THEN BRAND

THE LIST

FIG. 02 · CH 3

01

WHAT IS IT?

THE SHELF THE MIND FILES YOU ON

02

WHY DOES IT MATTER?

RELEVANCE — WHERE POSITIONING DIES

03

WHY YOU, NOT A SUBSTITUTE?

THE ONE THING A FORK CAN'T CARRY

04

WHY NOW?

WHAT MAKES YOU INEVITABLE, NOT OPTIONAL

THE FOUR QUESTIONS: THE RATIONAL SKELETON
EVERY BRAND IS BUILT ON.

"Marketing is the art of positioning."

Ekram, essay "Start with Positioning, not Branding," ekram.xyz.

Principle. Positioning is the claim you author: what you are, who for, why it matters, why now. Brand is the response that claim earns. You control one. You only influence the other. As Bezos put it and Ekram repeats, a brand is what people say when you are not in the

room. The order is fixed, and getting it backwards is the most common expensive mistake in frontier marketing. In his words. He frames the pair as rational and emotional:

Positioning is rational, branding is emotional. You need both. You position first before you build a brand.

Ekram, positioning keynote. Edited transcript excerpt.

A feeling has to be a feeling about something. Position first, or you are painting a portrait before deciding who is in it. Case: Celestia. (Tier 1, essay and keynote.) The positioning statement came first, flat and ownable:

"First modular blockchain network to power scalable, secure Web3 apps"

Celestia positioning statement, quoted by Ekram in the essay examples, ekram.xyz.

One word, "modular," that the market could carry and repeat. The brand came after, and from the culture rather than an agency. Its rallying line surfaced from the team itself, a story Chapter 10 tells in full. He signs the phrase himself:

"be different, build whatever"

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1861525667340525970>

Position first, the word the market owns. Brand second, the feeling that grows on it. The mistake. Treating a tagline as a position. The claim underneath a tagline is what a reporter would print with the hype stripped out. Ship the feeling without the claim and the market has nothing to file. Method. Answer what it is, why it

matters, why now, and why you, before you touch voice, color, or archetype. If any answer reaches for an adjective, it is not an answer yet.

Source. "Position first, then brand" is Cunningham's; the not-in-the-room line is Bezos's, repeated by Ekram. The rational-emotional split is an edited transcript excerpt.

4

SACRIFICE IS THE PRICE OF MEANING

His words carry this chapter; the arranger only holds the door.

"One of the lessons a mentor (who worked with Steve Jobs to launch the Macintosh) taught me: A great positioning strategy must hurt. The act is inherently an act of sacrifice. It should feel like you're giving something up. And that requires pain."

Ekram, 2026 (segment). <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2059011134146179424>

The mentor is Andy Cunningham; the hard edge is hers, and he keeps it sharp. A position is made by subtraction. A claim that fits everyone describes no one.

"You are either a wandering generality or a meaningful specific."

Ekram, essay "Sacrifice to find your Position," ekram.xyz, 2022.

The wandering generality is the default state of every ambitious company: capable of many things, therefore claiming many things, therefore filed as nothing. The exit is a cut that costs real money or a real audience.

"Every 'no' is a deeper 'yes' towards the audience that matters the most."

Ekram, essay "Sacrifice to find your Position," ekram.xyz, 2022.

In the keynote he runs the discipline through Solana: refuse the broad ground, take one axis, speed, and work until the market ranks the whole layer-one category by it. The sacrifice underneath is choosing who to ignore. (Edited transcript excerpt.) He reads the same discipline in Solana's sub-brands:

"Solana is good at finding derivatives to underscore their strategic position. Breakpoint, Lightspeed, and now Blink. These brands are all saying the same thing: "speed kills"."

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1805630020431519809>

One warning, and one test. The warning: a list of no's that costs nothing is a description, and any rival can hold it too. The test: list what the company will stop being, name the audience you are not for, say it out loud. If the list does not sting, cut deeper. The wince is the signal.

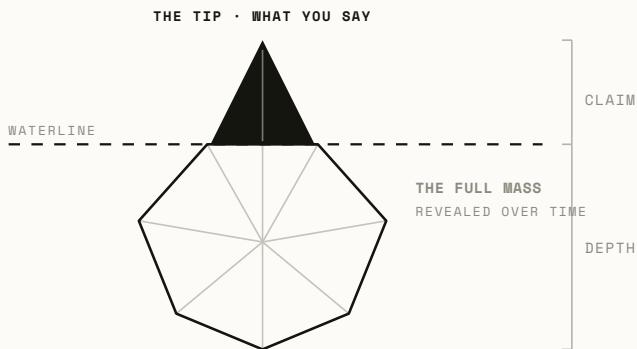
Source. The Law of Sacrifice is Ries and Trout. The must-hurt edge is Cunningham: the tweet above credits an unnamed mentor, and Ekram names her in the keynote. The Solana narration is edited transcript.

5

MAKE THE POSITION FIT IN THE MIND

THE ICEBERG

FIG. 03 · CH 5



COMMUNICATE ONLY THE TIP. REVEAL THE MASS AS
YOU EARN THE RIGHT TO WIDEN.

"The name is the thesis."

Ekram, 2026 (segment). <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2069484019264491658>

A position has to travel through distracted minds, so it has to be small enough to carry. Naming and language are compression, and this chapter is the compression toolkit. The four-way test. Run every name, phrase, and line of launch copy through one question: does it explain, compress, provoke, or merely decorate. Keep the first three. Kill the fourth. The name test. When a project called Engram

crossed his feed, his whole read of the name was the method in one move:

"clever name. In neuroscience, an engram is the physical trace of a memory stored in the brain. The name is the thesis."

Ekram, 2026. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2069484019264491658>

The name does the positioning work before a single feature is explained. Ask what future your name tells the market to expect.

When a product line's names sprawl instead, the market cannot build a ladder of what beats what:

"OpenAI naming committee has seen things"

Ekram, 2026. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2070567702557765691>

Statement, then tagline. In the keynote he separates the two cleanly. "No Software" for Salesforce, "One Click" for Amazon, "only possible on Solana": taglines. A positioning statement is the matter-of-fact articulation of who you are and why you matter; the tagline is the emotional one-liner that expresses it. Ship the tagline while skipping the statement and you have a mood with nothing under it. (Edited transcript excerpt.) Dead language. Most launch copy is packing material the market is trained to skip:

"The whole 'we're excited to announce...' opening is SO overdone"

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1770937126646931499>

Cut every phrase that only sounds like a launch. What survives the cut is your actual language: the words doing explain, compress,

or provoke work. There will be fewer of them than you wrote.
Good.

Source. The statement-versus-tagline teaching is an edited transcript excerpt from the keynote.

INTERLUDE I

On Position

"You are either a wandering generality or a meaningful specific."

Essay, "Sacrifice to find your Position," ekram .xyz, 2022.

"For marketing, the battle is more about perception than products"

2023. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1627694511819464705>

"Fame isn't always relevance. You can be famous in this world, but irrelevant at the same time. Relevance is achieved through positioning, and then repositioning when the conversation moves away from you."

2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1812085910801981467>

"The "first" positioning has a shelf-life."

Segment, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1825955014986379466>

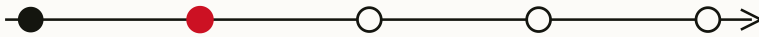
"wild how a single tweet thread that shifts perception can be more efficient than 100 BD calls"

2025. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1969218903134949520>

Category

What game are you making the market play?

you are filed on. You have three moves: create a new category, enter an existing one and win an axis, or make the leader's category feel old. Category work is where positioning turns into strategy, because it sets the comparison the market judges you by. Get it right and the comparison flatters you. Get it wrong and you spend years arguing on someone else's terms.



INVISIBLE

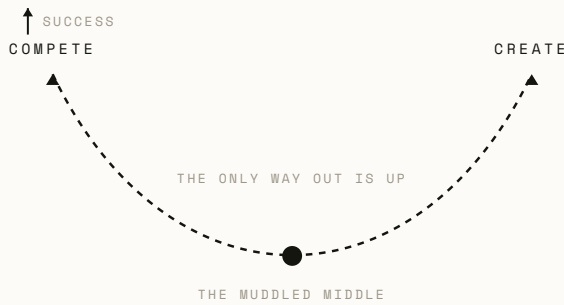
INEVITABLE

6

CREATE THE CATEGORY OR ENTER THE FIGHT

THE EXITS

FIG. 04 · CH 6



BOTH ENDS WIN; THE BOTTOM IS WHERE THE
COMPANY FLATTENS OUT.

"everyone wants to create a new market category.few have the will to define and teach it. even fewer have the discipline to stay on message."

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1806044294308122990>

Principle. Three moves, three bills. Create a category and you own a word, but you carry the burden of education. Enter an existing category and you inherit its demand, but you fight on a visible axis forever. Position against the leader and you borrow their attention, but you live in their shadow until you break out. The one move that never works is the straddle: "new and better" is two stories, and the market holds neither. In

his words. Ekram frames the fork through David Sacks' two formulas:

The Jordan Way is to compete and win, and to double down when the competition gets fierce. The Thiel Way is to avoid competition and create your own game.

The middle is where most brands die. There is a graveyard of teams who chose the Thiel path and could not carry the burden of education.

Ekram, positioning keynote. Edited transcript excerpt. (Jordan versus Thiel is David Sacks, cited by Ekram; the differentiation modes are Andy Cunningham.)

Case: same market, two games. In the keynote, Ekram runs both moves through the layer-one market. Solana played Jordan: it stayed inside the category, declared speed the axis that matters, and worked to make the market rank everyone by it. Celestia played Thiel: it refused the race and created a new category, modular, so the old comparison stopped applying. Same market, two legitimate games, neither straddling. The Jordan bill is proof and defense, because the moment you win an axis, rivals copy it. The Thiel bill is patience, because a new word means nobody understands you yet. Method. Say the word out loud: Jordan or Thiel. Name the axis you will win on, or the category you will define. Then price the bill. If you cannot pay for proof and defense, do not pick Jordan. If you cannot teach for a year, do not pick Thiel. And keep the endgame in view:

"Eventually, every category becomes a two-car race"

Ekram, 2022. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1558271694283816960>

Source. Jordan versus Thiel is David Sacks, cited by Ekram; the three differentiation modes are Cunningham. Both come from the keynote.

7

TEACH THE CATEGORY UNTIL IT
BECOMES INEVITABLE

THE TEACHING STACK

FIG. 05 · CH 7

NAME THE CATEGORY	01
DEFINE THE PROBLEM	02
HAND OVER THE LANGUAGE	03
RECRUIT RIVALS	04
REPEAT UNTIL ECHOED	05 · LOOP

WORK THE ORDER: NAME IT, DEFINE IT, GIVE THE
LANGUAGE AWAY, THEN REPEAT.

"coordinating with rivals makes the category inevitable"

Ekram, 2026. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2036164302659526939>

Bangkok, November 2024. One post from Ekram lists the week's gatherings, and the category is baked into the names: Modular Bangkok. Modular Brunch. Modular Acceleration. Provable Bangkok. A wall of events, each one putting the same word in front of the ecosystem again. Nothing about that list is an

accident. Celestia had coined "modular" years earlier, and coining the word was the easy part. A category only becomes real when other projects, media, and even competitors start using its language. Until then it is a claim one company makes about itself, and the market distrusts a market of one. So the work after the word is teaching: define the problem, hand the language to others, and repeat it until the market says it back without you. The hardest part of that teaching is generosity toward rivals. From the keynote, on the modular narrative:

The modular narrative is only as good as its inclusiveness. It is important for other projects to identify as modular. There is no such thing as a category of one, so you make sure other projects feel comfortable identifying as modular and have the resources to build in it.

Ekram, positioning keynote. Edited transcript excerpt.

Read the Bangkok list again with that in mind. Every event is the category being taught. The rivals who show up become proof that the category is bigger than one project, which is the entire point. Fence the word off and it stays yours and stays small. Give it away and it becomes the board everyone plays on, with your company standing at the door. The method follows the case. Name the category. Define the problem it solves in one sentence. Recruit other players into it, including rivals, and give them the language and the resources to adopt it. Then teach on a loop until the market repeats it without crediting you. The day a competitor calls themselves by your category name, you have won.

Source. The inclusiveness passage is edited transcript; the event names are described from the linked tweet, not quoted. The reading of the list is ours.

8

MAKE THE COMPETITOR FEEL HISTORICAL

"The best way to kill your competitor is to make them feel historical. I meet a lot of founders who refuse to antagonize their main competitor."

Ekram, 2026 (segment). <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2059706055291232673>

Superiority is an argument, and the market has to check arguments. A frame skips the check. Name an old world and a new world, stand at the door of the new one, and the leader gets filed as the past before anyone examines a feature.

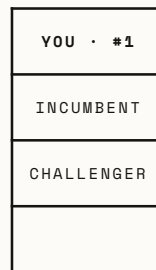
TWO LADDERS

FIG. 06 · CH 8

AXIS: THEIRS



AXIS: YOURS · YOUR POV



SAME PLAYERS · DIFFERENT AXIS · A NEW #1

PICK THE AXIS, YOUR POV, AND YOU DECIDE WHO
RANKS #1.

"There's a saying in politics that the strongest way to unite a people is through a common enemy. I've found the same principle applies effectively in marketing and branding."

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1823441724599075044>

"Antagonists to the brand create urgency and relevance. Strangely, 98% of founders I meet are too soft to choose one."

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1804530184646791577>

In the keynote he borrows the mechanic from political communication: anchor the audience onto a single word that engineers a bias against the rival, the way a campaign brands an opponent with one sticky label. You are not calling the competitor bad. You are choosing the lens the market reads them through. (Edited transcript excerpt.) Pick the fight carefully, though. Some prizes shrink while you win them:

"Being #1 in a shrinking market isn't a flex. Play stupid games. Win stupid prizes."

Ekram, 2025. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1920530990184771936>

The same move works even when the enemy is not a named competitor. Sometimes the rival is a frame: the old debate, the accusation, the category the market is trying to trap you inside. The job then changes from dunking on a company to making the frame itself feel too small for the future now arriving. Call it the historical move at category scale: stop defending yourself, and change what the argument is about. A later moment shows the move run outside a direct rivalry. When Anthropic found itself at the center of a public fight, Ekram's read of its statement was one line:

"The most interesting line in Anthropic's statement is the one where the debate stops being about Anthropic. Turn your case into a category question."

Ekram, 2026. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2065631212643975402>

The accusation was the frame. Anthropic's statement made that frame feel obsolete.

One warning. Antagonism that is only an insult reads as insecurity and ages badly. The frame has to point at a real shift, an old world that is actually ending, or it is noise aimed at a rival. Name the old world, the new world, and the reason the old leader cannot cross over without betraying what made them. Then let the market carry the comparison. The market inherits a frame before it fact-checks one.

Source. The frame-control mechanic is from the positioning keynote, used here as an edited transcript excerpt. The Anthropic read comes from his linked tweet; framing it as the historical move at category scale is ours.

INTERLUDE II

On Enemies And Categories

"Two threats to worry about more than your competition: - internal conflict - market inertia"

2022. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1602403016551825408>

"Competition can lead protocols down the wrong path. One can get stuck playing someone else's game"

2023. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1625653105638658049>

"Category leaders welcome and embrace competition. Responding negatively signals insecurity and someone unfit to lead."

2022. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1588244458155298816>

"smart marketers harness cultural trends. The smartest create them"

2023. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1644347019006480384>

PART III

Belief

What do people feel, join, and repeat?

Position makes you legible. It does not make anyone care. This movement is the emotional layer: the feeling your position earns, the culture that turns customers into a tribe, and the founder who becomes the compression point for all of it. Legible is the floor. Desirable is the charge, and it runs on emotion, not specs.



9

BRAND IS A RESPONSE YOU EARN

"It's a response to your positioning, not a stimulus."

Ekram, essay "Start with Positioning, not Branding," ekram.xyz.

Principle. You do not ship a brand. You send signals: a message, a product, a launch. Whatever sticks in other people's heads is the brand. The only levers you hold are your position and your behavior; the brand is the output. Which is why "let's build a brand" is the wrong first move, and why a feeling has to be a feeling about something. In his words. In the keynote he traces the word back to cattle ranching, a mark burned to tell animals apart, then lands the point:

A brand is a prize. It is a response you earn. You send a signal, you stimulate the market, some of it lands and some of it doesn't, and whatever lands chisels a perception. That perception is the brand.

Ekram, positioning keynote. Edited transcript excerpt.

The diagnostic: no FUD, no brand. If the market feels nothing about you, it will not bother to attack you, and indifference is the real failure state.

"The most distinct sign of irrelevance is no-FUD. If no one is trying to undermine, criticize, or cast doubt on you, it's a stark indicator that you aren't important enough to be worth attacking."

Ekram, 2025. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1889415909548462352>

"Be very worried about the absence of attacks on the brand.
Means ppl don't give a shit"

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1823196501243473933>

Case: a response, witnessed. (Tier 1, his own read.) Watch him catch the moment a brand comes back from the market:

"Succinct's brand personality seems to really be shining through lately. Unique blend of spontaneity, wit and power."

Ekram, 2025. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1889502494784627142>

Note what he is describing. Nobody at Succinct shipped "spontaneity, wit and power" as a deliverable. They sent signals; the market returned a personality, and an outside strategist could name the feeling without being prompted. A brand exists on the day someone else can describe it. The mistake. Diluting the signal until no response can form:

"Using 'partnership' in every announcement dilutes the brand.
The word is so overused it has lost its meaning."

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1801438746988163375>

Method. Name the one emotional response you want repeated without prompting. Audit your last month of signals, the product,

the copy, the launches, and ask what feeling they actually earned. If the honest answer is "none," you do not have a brand yet. You have a position waiting for one.

Source. The prize-and-response passage is edited transcript. The Succinct line is his; the interpretation is ours.

10

CULTURE IS THE MOAT WHEN IT
GIVES IDENTITY

THE FOUR-PART TEST

FIG. 07 · CH 10

01 THE SHARED BELIEF

02 THE UNWRITTEN RULE

03 THE TABOO

04 THE INSIDER SIGNAL

IF NONE OF THE FOUR ARE TRUE YET, YOU HAVE
CUSTOMERS, NOT A CULTURE.

"The primary battlefield of prediction markets is shifting to culture. Culture has infinite surface area."

Ekram, 2026 (segment). <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2028903593290662313>

An onsite, somewhere in Celestia's early years. The team is workshopping, and a phrase surfaces from the room: build whatever. Nobody bought it from an agency. It stuck because it already described the people in the room, and it went on to become the most repeated line the project owns. In the keynote, Ekram tells the story as the model for

where brand language should come from. He signs the phrase himself:

"be different, build whatever"

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1861525667340525970>

A tagline that grows out of the culture is defensible in a way a bolted-on slogan never is, because the community is already living it before it is written down. Culture is the inside-out source code of the brand, and its commercial engine is identity. People gather around brands that tell them who they are becoming, and identity is where the loyalty lives:

"it taps deeper into identity, which means more passion, more loyalty, and ultimately more liquidity"

Ekram, 2026 (segment). <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2028903593290662313>

He repeats one inherited law on this:

"One of my most repeated learnings in this game: culture eats strategy."

Ekram, 2025. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1971617747017826730>

The phrase is Peter Drucker's, and Ekram credits it as inherited. His application is the original part: culture as a positioning tool a strategy must be built to fit, never an afterthought. A sharp strategy carried by a culture that contradicts it loses to the culture every time. The same force lets a company trade a product identity for a mission. Ekram flagged the move at Midjourney, an AI image company repositioning itself as a community-supported research lab:

"less product, more mission"

Ekram, 2026 (segment). <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2067441661123391984>

The working test has four parts. Write the belief the tribe shares, the unwritten rule it polices, the taboo it will not cross, and the insider signal that marks a member. If none of those are true yet, you have customers, not a culture, and the moat is still a moat drawing.

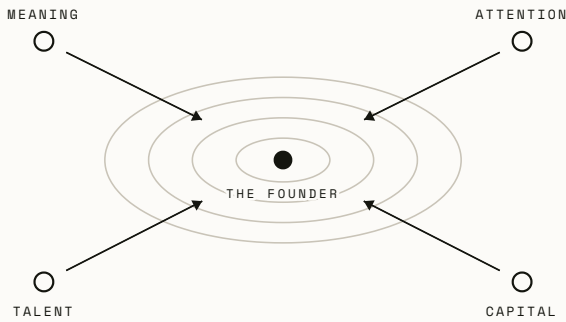
Source. "Culture eats strategy" is Drucker's, credited; the onsite story is edited transcript; the four-part test is ours.

11

THE FOUNDER IS THE LIGHTNING ROD

THE WELL

FIG. 08 · CH 11



MASS BENDS THE FIELD: MEANING, ATTENTION,
TALENT, CAPITAL ROLL TOWARD THE FOUNDER.

"The founder is the lightning rod to the brand"

Ekram, 2025. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1879257403390394622>

Early markets cannot evaluate companies. The product is unfinished, the metrics are noise, the claims all sound alike. So the market reads the founder instead: their taste, their risk appetite, their conviction, and it prices the company off the person. One human becomes the compression point for everything the company means, whether anyone planned it or not. Ekram watches this mechanism the way a meteorologist watches pressure systems. He has named its stages. There is the debut, where status is borrowed before it is earned:

"some of the fastest founder visibility ascents I've seen start with triangulation as the debut move. basically showing up next to two other founders who already have the status they want."

Ekram, 2026 (segment). <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2013779817435668526>

There is the amplification layer, which the founder does not control alone:

"People look at your inner-circle, your disciples. If they're silent or mid, it dims the brand. But if they're sharp, vocal, and credible, it creates pull."

Ekram, 2025 (segment). <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1915520650674135110>

And there is the terminal stage, where the person stops being a communicator and becomes a symbol. Ekram's live example was Roy Lee, the founder of the AI startup Cluely, whose public provocations had become a bigger story than his product:

"What we're watching is the early formation of a cult-of-personality. Roy is becoming the Gen Z symbol of defiance, embodying what many founders secretly wish they had the courage to say."

Ekram, 2026 (segment). <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2031200935314338160>

At full charge, the market stops buying the product and buys what the founder represents instead. Ekram calls the posture main character mode, the marketing analogue to Paul Graham's founder mode (" 'Main character mode' is the marketing analogue to PGs Founder mode," 2024). The physics cut both ways, and this caution is ours rather than his. The same concentration that makes belief

compound also concentrates blame. A founder who becomes the symbol of the upside becomes the symbol of the collapse if it comes. The rod attracts the strike as well as the charge, and that is the bargain you accept when you put a human at the center of the brand. So the decision has three parts, made on purpose rather than by drift. Find the founder's authentic edge and the one visible, costly risk they will take in public, because the market prices risk taken, not words. Curate the people who echo them, because the signal compounds through the inner circle or dims there. And decide whether the brand should wear a face at all, knowing what the face will absorb in both directions. A market that cannot read your company will read your founder. Choose what it finds.

Source. The disciples and triangulation lines are quoted as em-dash-free segments of longer posts. Roy Lee's identification as Cluely's founder is public record; Ekram's tweet names only "Roy." The rod-cuts-both-ways caution is ours, with no named case.

INTERLUDE III

On Narrative And Time

"months are noise. years are truth"

2025. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1932232367789293740>

"Visibility breeds admiration, admiration sparks imitation, imitation fuels narrative"

2025. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1908342253745324346>

"Over time, you realize that one of the biggest levers to storytelling is choosing where to begin"

2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1818685442935734297>

"Crypto is filled with technical narratives. It's the projects that manage to communicate an authentic social narrative that punch through the noise"

2022. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1587558012469665792>

"Crafting narrative and placing narrative are two different arts"

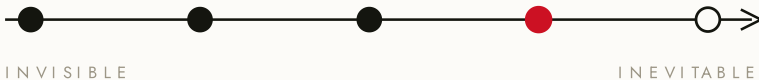
2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1821226556628652145>

PART IV

Inevitability

What future are you pulling forward?

Desirable makes people want you. Inevitable makes them believe you are where things are already going. This movement is about time: a narrative that makes a future feel priced in, and an alarm that makes the cost of waiting visible. Inevitability de-risks you in the market's mind, because a bet on a direction feels safer than a bet on a company.



12

NARRATIVE IS THE FRONTLINE

His words carry this chapter; the arranger only holds the door.

"If the war is attention, narrative is the frontline"

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1864023288999031153>

A narrative is the future the company makes more believable, and in frontier markets that future often arrives before the product does:

"In crypto, narrative market-fit often precedes product market-fit"

Ekram, 2022. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1536782146265788417>

Belief organizes the market before there is anything to point at. Which raises the question of how you tell a real narrative from a decorated slogan. He has a test:

"One way to test narrative power is to ask: If our company disappeared tomorrow, what future would no longer happen? The question isn't what product disappears if you shut down tomorrow. It's what future gets pushed further away."

Ekram, 2026. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2065569545465794561>

If the honest answer is "nothing," you have a product, not a narrative. The future has to recede when you leave the room. The

second discipline is holding. A narrative becomes inevitable only if it stays the same narrative long enough for the market to trust it:

"No amount of money can save a brand that changes its narrative and messaging every 6 months"

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1808170739750916317>

The whole method fits in two sentences. Write the future that recedes if you disappear, in one sentence. Then say that one thing a hundred ways, and hold it for years, because drift resets the clock and refusing to change the subject is the discipline.

Source. All four lines verbatim, linked above. The two-sentence method is ours.

13

SOUND THE ALARM

"One comms strategy is to outright create the crisis. Signal warning. Unite tribes. Articulate ramifications. Channel that alarm into market action."

Ekram, 2023. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1616251011982823424>

November 2024. Ethereum researcher Justin Drake announces Beam Chain, a proposal to renew Ethereum's consensus layer. A real problem, a serious researcher, a major stage. And Ekram scores it as a failure:

"It was a communications blunder"

Ekram, 2024 (segment). <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1856582705045278824>

His diagnosis, from the same post, came down to two phrases: "Poor problem framing" and a "prolonged timeline." The existing chain was cast as old and frozen, which supplies the danger. But the fix was years away, so the danger had no deadline, and an alarm with no near-term cost never converts into action. The announcement produced discourse instead of urgency. A danger with no clock is an announcement, and the market filed it as one. The doctrine hiding in that failure: strong positioning often names a danger, because the market moves when the cost of doing nothing becomes visible. But alarm and hype are different instruments. Hype inflates a reward that may never arrive. Alarm makes a real, already-moving downside legible. What separates them is whether a genuine shift sits

underneath, and whether the deadline is close enough to bite. Beam Chain had the shift and lost the deadline. The sharpest operators compress the choice into a fork with no middle. Ekram studied the pattern:

"Been studying the power of binary outcomes in brand narrative lately."

Ekram, 2024 (segment). <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1849912273042854389>

In that post he reads Elon's companies as binaries: SpaceX as Mars or extinction, Tesla as sustainable energy or climate crisis, Neuralink as AI or obsolescence. Name the fork and inaction starts to feel like choosing the bad branch. The mechanic is portable; the honesty requirement travels with it. The method, learned from the failure: name what happens if the market ignores the shift, and make the deadline close enough to bite. If there is no real downside and no near-term cost, you are running hype, and the market eventually prices the difference.

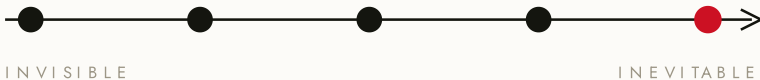
Source. The Beam Chain diagnosis phrases are verbatim segments of his linked post; the Elon binaries are described from his post. The urgency-versus-hype distinction is ours.

PART V

Delivery

How does the position enter the market and survive contact?

A position that never ships is a private opinion. This last movement is delivery: the launch that files your position as an event, and the attention war that decides whether belief compounds or evaporates after the glance. Everything upstream, meaning and category and belief and inevitability, meets the market here.

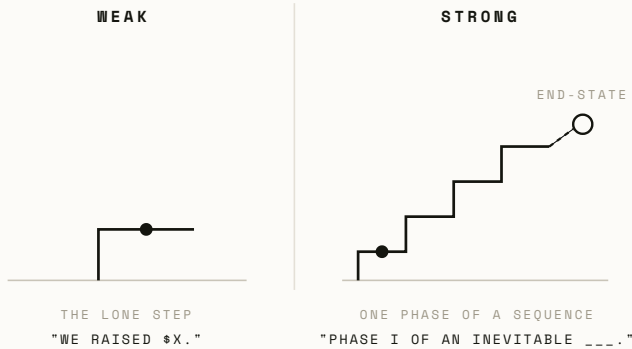


14

LAUNCH AS A POSITIONING EVENT

WEAK VS STRONG

FIG. 09 · CH 14



A NUMBER BECOMES MOMENTUM WHEN FRAMED AS ONE
PHASE OF AN INEVITABLE SEQUENCE.

"The list is the positioning."

Ekram, 2026. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2071972042518512053>

June 2026. Open USD launches, and the announcement leads with a number that has nothing to do with features: over 140 businesses assembled behind it. Ekram's read:

"over 140 businesses were brought together to launch Open USD. Rarely do we see a launch intentionally overwhelm with this level of industry support. The list is the positioning."

Ekram, 2026. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2071972042518512053>

The 140 names are not packaging around the launch. They are the launch. A wall of credible backers announced together proves inevitability before a single feature is explained, because the market reads proof, backers, timing, and coalition long before it reads copy. He caught the same move at institutional scale:

"LayerZero sent an insane coordination signal. Pretty sure this is the first time institutions that run some of the world's largest markets "converged" on a public chain architecture before launch."

Ekram, 2026 (segment). <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2021715757797978248>

Backing delivered in one moment collapses the will-this-survive doubt faster than any argument could. The logos are not the point; the simultaneity is. A launch can also file a direction instead of a data point. He contrasted a capital announcement with a trajectory announcement:

"One of the biggest mistakes in fundraising announcements is announcing the capital without positioning the trajectory. Notice what Variational did here with "Phase I". They didn't frame this as a product launch. They framed it as the beginning of a multi-phase market transition."

Ekram, 2026. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2057142394831921634>

"Phase I" tells the market this is one step in a sequence already underway. It sells the trajectory, not the milestone. Three cases, one method. Before you write the announcement, decide what it must prove: inevitability, momentum, a coalition, a direction. Stage the proof, the list, the coordination signal, the phase, so the market reads it first. Then, and only then, write what it says.

Source. All three launch reads are his, linked; the prove-before-say framing is ours.

15

WIN ATTENTION, THEN DEFEND IT

"Attention war over people's ADD today is all too real."

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1800730344674701554>

Attention is the scarce input, and winning the glance is only the start. The work runs in three moves: create it, put it where it lives, defend it when the story turns. Run them as a checklist. Create it. The content that travels is a hard idea made shareable without losing the insight:

"Often what spreads the most in crypto is when you take a high IQ concept and meme it into more approachable forms."

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1805061060447359208>

And it is earned, never bought:

"Like respect, attention is earned"

Ekram, 2022. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1570076419719581703>

Name the attention source and how you earn it. Then name the proof that has to follow, or the attention decays into a memory of a glance. Channel it. The channels move under your feet, so check where attention actually lives before you spend on it:

"Streaming has overtaken podcasting as crypto's dominant media format."

Ekram, 2025 (segment). <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1966590732745273451>

Defend it. The moment the story turns, control goes to whoever speaks first and fullest. His crisis spine is one line:

"In other words, he or she who discloses first, wins."

Ekram, essay "Issue Full Disclosure," ekram.xyz.

The second move is the reframe, and he named its mechanism years before most founders needed it:

"In crisis-communications, identify a 'pivot-point', shifting attention from A to B"

Ekram, 2022. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1565912551681957888>

Case: Euler. (Tier 2, public record; his line below is the extent of what he said.) In March 2023 the lending protocol Euler suffered one of DeFi's largest hacks, roughly two hundred million dollars drained in a morning. The team disclosed immediately, negotiated with the attacker in public, and recovered the funds within weeks. Then it made the defense permanent: it kept the name. No rebrand, no distancing, the history owned in full. Ekram read the choice as the relaunch approached:

"Euler keeping the same name is interesting. Sets them up for a comeback narrative. Respect."

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1832155880575660160>

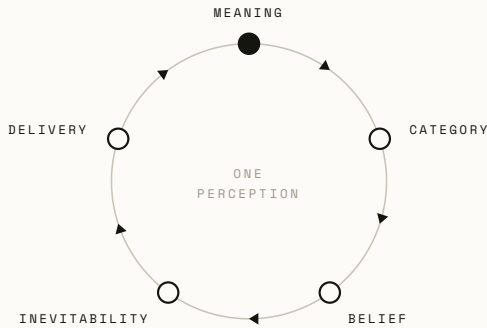
A rebrand would have spent the crisis. The kept name invested it: the protocol relaunched under the same flag, and the hack became the first chapter of a comeback story instead of the last chapter of a failure. The crisis page, written before you need it. Disclose first, fast, and full. Acknowledge plainly, no euphemism. Find the pivot-point and shift the story from the accusation to the answer. Decide today who reviews the response before it posts, because you will not have time to decide it during.

Source. The create-channel-defend frame is ours. The pivot-point line and the Euler read are verbatim, linked; the Euler facts (the 2023 hack, the public recovery, the relaunch under the same name) are public record, and the reading of the name choice is ours.

16

THE POSITIONING MACHINE

THE CYCLE · THE PERCEPTION LOOP FIG. 10 · CH 16



FIVE MOVES, ONE LOOP: EVERY STAGE FEEDS A
SINGLE PERCEPTION.

Celestia, the method made visible. This book runs in parts because that is how you learn it. It ships as one machine. Here is the whole thing turning at once, in a company that ran every stage of it in public. Meaning. Celestia could have arrived as one more layer-one and been filed as one more layer-one. It refused the default and built the position on a word the market could own, flat and factual and repeatable:

"First modular blockchain network to power scalable, secure Web3 apps"

Celestia positioning statement, quoted by Ekram in the essay examples, ekram.xyz.

Modular was the position. The feeling came later. The word came first. Category. Modular was not a feature; it was a new category, the Thiel move, and a category of one is a category of none. So Celestia did the expensive part and taught it, pulling rivals in rather than fencing the word off:

"coordinating with rivals makes the category inevitable"

Ekram, 2026. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2036164302659526939>

The teaching was made physical: the run of gatherings with the category baked into their names, until the word sat in front of the ecosystem more often than any argument for it. (Chapter 7 holds the Bangkok list.) Belief. The brand came from the culture, surfacing from the team at an onsite and sticking because it already described them:

"be different, build whatever"

Ekram, 2024. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1861525667340525970>

Position first, the word the market owns. Brand second, the feeling the tribe wears. Inevitability. Because the story arrived before the product was finished, it organized builders on belief, which is how frontier markets often move:

"In crypto, narrative market-fit often precedes product market-fit"

Ekram, 2022. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1536782146265788417>

Modular held long enough to enter the market's language. That is the real win. The word stopped belonging only to Celestia and became a way the market described a whole architecture, a whole debate, a whole board. People could argue for modular, against modular, or build inside modular, but they were now using the frame. Delivery. The category entered the market the same way it was taught: events, ecosystem teaching, and adopters taking the modular language as their own. Each adoption proved the category was larger than one team. The list, again, was the positioning. The machine. Run the stages back to back and the seams disappear. The position set the category. The category needed teaching, so the culture and the events carried it. The culture produced a brand the tribe wanted to wear. The narrative held long enough to become market language, and delivery fed the whole loop back to meaning. Five movements, one perception, authored on purpose and compounded through every stage. The payoff is not a tagline. The payoff is who shows up:

"One of the coolest aspects of Celestia is the caliber of builders one gets to meet. Always impressed by the sheer scope of ambition and drive to build global brands. Life is too short to be around anyone else."

Ekram, 2025. <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1889369329277477049>

The boundary. The honest lesson is sharper than the victory lap. Modular entering the language proved what positioning can do, and

only that. A word can win the board while the company behind it still competes for builders, liquidity, attention, and time. Reality still collects: product, execution, timing. Chapter 2 named this law before the machine ever turned: the story is the existence the market meets first, and reality is the one that decides whether anyone stays. The machine authors the first existence. The second one is earned. Story creates the board. Reality decides how long you keep your seat.

Source. The positioning statement is from the essay; the no-category-of-one teaching is edited transcript, held in Chapter 7. The closing builders line is verbatim, linked above. The machine passage and the boundary are the arranger's synthesis: modular won language adoption, but category language is not company destiny.

A. The Core Methods

The book compressed into its operating moves, each mapping to a chapter. This is the book's method language, distilled from the sourced doctrine; the verbatim Ekram lines behind these moves are collected in Section B. Use it as a working checklist, not a summary to admire.

— PART I · MEANING

- 1 Before you write your position, write the lazy one the market will assign by default, then decide if you can live with it. (Ch 1)
- 2 Define and control the narrative, or someone else will. The sentence about your company gets written either way; the only choice is the author. (Ch 1)
- 3 Write what the company is in one sentence and what the market says it is in one sentence. The gap is the work. (Ch 2)
- 4 Guard the second existence, the story, as hard as the product. The market acts on the story, not the reality. (Ch 2)
- 5 Know what forks and what does not: the code copies, the earned meaning does not. (Ch 2)
- 6 Answer what it is, why it matters, why now, and why you, before you touch voice, color, or archetype. (Ch 3)
- 7 Author the position; earn the brand. Never engineer a feeling about a thing you have not defined. (Ch 3)

- 8 Sharpen by subtraction. Name what the company will stop being and the audience it is not for, out loud. (Ch 4)
- 9 If the list of no's does not sting, cut deeper. A costless position is a copyable one. (Ch 4)
- 10 Run every name and phrase through one test: does it explain, compress, provoke, or merely decorate. (Ch 5)
- 11 Write the factual positioning statement first, then let the tagline express it. Never ship the tagline alone. (Ch 5)
- 12 Cut dead launch language that carries no position. (Ch 5)

— PART II · CATEGORY

- 13 Say the word out loud: Jordan or Thiel. Compete on an axis, or create a category. Never straddle. (Ch 6)
- 14 Price the bill first: proof and defense for Jordan, education and patience for Thiel. (Ch 6)
- 15 Name the category, define the problem it solves, and recruit rivals into it. A category of one is a category of none. (Ch 7)
- 16 Make the teaching physical: turn the category word into events, gatherings, and repeated language. (Ch 7)
- 17 Teach on a loop until the market repeats your word without crediting you. (Ch 7)
- 18 Win the frame, not just the feature. Name an old world and a new world, and stand at the door of the new one. (Ch 8)

- 19** Choose the enemy deliberately: a rival, the status quo, or a whole category. Antagonize to create relevance, never to insult. (Ch 8)
- 20** Do not fight for the top of a shrinking market. (Ch 8)

— PART III · BELIEF

- 21** Name the one emotional response you want repeated without prompting, then audit whether your signals actually earn it. (Ch 9)
- 22** If no one bothers to attack you, you have no brand yet. Indifference is the real failure state. (Ch 9)
- 23** A brand exists on the day someone else can describe it. Until then, keep sending the signal. (Ch 9)
- 24** Build the brand out of the culture, not an agency. A line the tribe already lives is defensible; a slogan bolted on is not. (Ch 10)
- 25** Write the belief, the unwritten rule, the taboo, and the insider signal. If none are true, you have customers, not a culture. (Ch 10)
- 26** Concentrate the brand into the founder's authentic edge and one visible, costly risk taken in public. (Ch 11)
- 27** Stage the people who echo the founder. The signal compounds through the inner circle, or it dims. (Ch 11)
- 28** Decide on purpose whether the brand wears a face, and accept that the rod attracts the strike as well as the charge. (Ch 11)

— PART IV · INEVITABILITY

- 29** Write the future that recedes if the company disappears. If nothing recedes, you have a product, not a narrative. (Ch 12)
- 30** Say one thing a hundred ways and hold it for years. Drift resets the clock. (Ch 12)
- 31** Name what happens if the market ignores the shift, and make the deadline close enough to bite. (Ch 13)
- 32** Separate alarm from hype: alarm makes a real, near-term downside visible; hype inflates a reward that may never arrive. (Ch 13)
- 33** When the shift is real, frame a binary future so inaction feels like choosing the bad branch. (Ch 13)

— PART V · DELIVERY

- 34** Design what the launch proves before what it says. Stage the proof, the list, the coalition, the phase, so the market reads it first. (Ch 14)
- 35** Use the coordination signal: a wall of credible backers announced together kills the will-this-survive doubt. (Ch 14)
- 36** Announce the trajectory, not the number. File a direction, not a data point. (Ch 14)
- 37** Create attention by making a hard idea shareable without losing the insight, and put it where attention now lives. (Ch 15)

- 38** Write the crisis move before you need it: disclose first, acknowledge plainly, find the pivot-point, and refuse to hand the narrative to the attacker. (Ch 15)

— CAPSTONE

- 39** Run the stages as one machine: the position sets the category, the category needs teaching, the culture carries it, the narrative holds it, and delivery feeds it back to meaning.
(Ch 16)
- 40** Judge the whole system by one output: who shows up. (Ch 16)

Source. This is the book's method language: editor synthesis distilled from the sourced chapters, not quotations.

B. Selected Quote Bank

Ekram's strongest lines, verbatim, organized by movement. A selection, not the full corpus. Tweets carry a year and a link; blog lines carry the essay. This section is strictly verbatim: edited transcript excerpts live labeled inside the chapters, and inherited canon such as "culture eats strategy" is credited in Section D. Where a source post contains an em dash, only an em-dash-free segment is quoted.

- "position, or be positioned." (2017)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/888465119717408768>
- "Define and control your narrative, or else someone else will."
Essay, Anchor the market, ekram.xyz.
- "Every company exists twice: once as reality, and once as the story people tell about it" (2026)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2067652948206010490>
- "You can't fork brand." (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1870995210161029238>
- "Marketing is the art of positioning." Essay, Start with Positioning, not Branding, ekram.xyz.
- "A great positioning strategy must hurt." (2026)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2059011134146179424>
- "You are either a wandering generality or a meaningful specific."
Essay, Sacrifice to find your Position, ekram.xyz.
- "Every "no" is a deeper "yes" towards the audience that matters the most." Essay, Sacrifice to find your Position, ekram.xyz.

- "The name is the thesis." (2026)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2069484019264491658>
- "Fame isn't always relevance. You can be famous in this world, but irrelevant at the same time." (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1812085910801981467>
- "For marketing, the battle is more about perception than products" (2023)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1627694511819464705>
- "everyone wants to create a new market category.few have the will to define and teach it. even fewer have the discipline to stay on message." (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1806044294308122990>
- "Eventually, every category becomes a two-car race" (2022)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1558271694283816960>
- "Category leaders welcome and embrace competition. Responding negatively signals insecurity and someone unfit to lead." (2022)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1588244458155298816>
- "coordinating with rivals makes the category inevitable" (2026)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2036164302659526939>
- "The best way to kill your competitor is to make them feel historical." (2026)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2059706055291232673>
- "There's a saying in politics that the strongest way to unite a people is through a common enemy. I've found the same principle applies effectively in marketing and branding." (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1823441724599075044>

- "Antagonists to the brand create urgency and relevance. Strangely, 98% of founders I meet are too soft to choose one." (2024) <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1804530184646791577>
- "Being #1 in a shrinking market isn't a flex. Play stupid games. Win stupid prizes." (2025) <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1920530990184771936>
- "Turn your case into a category question." (2026) <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2065631212643975402>
- "smart marketers harness cultural trends. The smartest create them" (2023) <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1644347019006480384>
- "It's a response to your positioning, not a stimulus." Essay, Start with Positioning, not Branding, ekram.xyz.
- "The most distinct sign of irrelevance is no-FUD. If no one is trying to undermine, criticize, or cast doubt on you, it's a stark indicator that you aren't important enough to be worth attacking." (2025) <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1889415909548462352>
- "Be very worried about the absence of attacks on the brand. Means ppl don't give a shit" (2024) <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1823196501243473933>
- "Succinct's brand personality seems to really be shining through lately. Unique blend of spontaneity, wit and power." (2025) <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1889502494784627142>
- "Using 'partnership' in every announcement dilutes the brand. The word is so overused it has lost its meaning." (2024) <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1801438746988163375>
- "The primary battlefield of prediction markets is shifting to culture. Culture has infinite surface area." (2026) <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2028903593290662313>

- "be different, build whatever" (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1861525667340525970>
- "One of my most repeated learnings in this game: culture eats strategy." (2025)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1971617747017826730>
- "The founder is the lightning rod to the brand" (2025)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1879257403390394622>
- "People look at your inner-circle, your disciples. If they're silent or mid, it dims the brand. But if they're sharp, vocal, and credible, it creates pull." (segment) (2025)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1915520650674135110>
- "'Main character mode' is the marketing analogue to PGs Founder mode" (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1830752907966455884>
- "If the war is attention, narrative is the frontline" (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1864023288999031153>
- "If our company disappeared tomorrow, what future would no longer happen?" (2026)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2065569545465794561>
- "No amount of money can save a brand that changes its narrative and messaging every 6 months" (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1808170739750916317>
- "In crypto, narrative market-fit often precedes product market-fit" (2022) <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1536782146265788417>
- "months are noise. years are truth" (2025)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1932232367789293740>

- "Visibility breeds admiration, admiration sparks imitation, imitation fuels narrative" (2025)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1908342253745324346>
- "Crafting narrative and placing narrative are two different arts" (2024) <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1821226556628652145>
- "One comms strategy is to outright create the crisis. Signal warning. Unite tribes. Articulate ramifications. Channel that alarm into market action." (2023)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1616251011982823424>
- "The list is the positioning." (2026)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2071972042518512053>
- "One of the biggest mistakes in fundraising announcements is announcing the capital without positioning the trajectory." (2026)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2057142394831921634>
- "Attention war over people's ADD today is all too real." (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1800730344674701554>
- "Often what spreads the most in crypto is when you take a high IQ concept and meme it into more approachable forms." (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1805061060447359208>
- "Like respect, attention is earned" (2022)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1570076419719581703>
- "Streaming has overtaken podcasting as crypto's dominant media format." (2025)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1966590732745273451>
- "In other words, he or she who discloses first, wins." Essay, Issue Full Disclosure, ekram.xyz.

- "In crisis-communications, identify a "pivot-point", shifting attention from A to B" (2022)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1565912551681957888>
- "Euler keeping the same name is interesting. Sets them up for a comeback narrative. Respect." (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1832155880575660160>

Source. Every line above is verbatim: a tweet with its year and link, or a blog line with its essay. The disciples line is quoted as an em-dash-free segment because the original contains an em dash. No edited transcript, inherited canon, method language, or unverified line appears in this section.

C. Case Library

The book's cases in one place, by movement. Each names the tier, the chapter it serves, the positioning move it proves, and its source basis, keeping public fact separate from Ekram's own words. Tiers: T1, Ekram spoke about it on the record; T2, editor-analyzed market moment, public fact plus a labeled reading.

Worldcoin Ch 1

T 2

PROVES the market files you by the nearest vivid image, so a sharp thesis can lose to a mockable picture.

PUBLIC FACT the iris-scanning orb and the privacy backlash, with pauses or probes in several countries.

SOURCE Ekram: "Idk about this 'verified humans.'" (2025)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1917795103994761670>

Uniswap and SushiSwap Ch 2

T 2

PROVES the code forks, the position does not.

PUBLIC FACT the 2020 SushiSwap fork and vampire attack; Uniswap stayed the default.

SOURCE Ekram: "You can't fork brand." (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1870995210161029238>

Celestia: modular Ch 3

T1

PROVES position first, the word the market can own, then earn the brand.

SOURCE The positioning statement quoted in his essay; the brand's onsite origin and "be different, build whatever" (2024)

<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1861525667340525970> are held in full in Chapter 10.

Solana: speed Ch 4

T1

PROVES sacrifice, choose one axis and give up the rest.

SOURCE Ekram: "Solana is good at finding derivatives to underscore their strategic position. Breakpoint, Lightspeed, and now Blink. These brands are all saying the same thing: 'speed kills.'" (2024)

<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1805630020431519809>; the sacrifice narration is a labeled keynote excerpt.

Engram, and OpenAI naming Ch 5

T1

PROVES the name carries the thesis; a naming sprawl loses the ladder.

SOURCE Ekram: the Engram read (2026)

<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2069484019264491658>; "OpenAI naming committee has seen things" (2026)

<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2070567702557765691>

Solana (Jordan) and Celestia (Thiel) Ch 6

T1

PROVES same market, two legitimate games; the straddle loses.

SOURCE The positioning keynote, labeled edited transcript.

Celestia teaches modular Ch 7

T1

PROVES a category of one is a category of none; teach it and recruit rivals.

SOURCE Ekram: the coordinating-with-rivals line (2026)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2036164302659526939>; the 2024 Bangkok events post <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1854749277089841469>

Anthropic Ch 8

T1

PROVES when the enemy is a frame rather than a rival, reframe your moment as the category's question, so the debate stops being about you.

SOURCE Ekram: "Turn your case into a category question." (2026)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2065631212643975402>

Succinct Ch 9

T1

PROVES a brand exists when the market can describe the feeling back.

SOURCE Ekram: the brand-personality read (2025)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1889502494784627142>

Celestia "build whatever," and Midjourney Ch 10

T1

PROVES brand grows from culture, not an agency; mission can replace product identity.

SOURCE Ekram: the tagline tweet (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1861525667340525970>; "less product, more mission" (2026) <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2067441661123391984>

Roy Lee Ch 11

T 1

PROVES the founder becomes a symbol people wear.

SOURCE Ekram: the cult-of-personality read (2026)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2031200935314338160>

Beam Chain, and Elon's binaries Ch 13

T 1

PROVES alarm needs a near-term deadline; a binary future makes a shift urgent.

SOURCE Ekram: "It was a communications blunder" with the "Poor problem framing" and "prolonged timeline" diagnosis (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1856582705045278824>; the binary-outcomes post (2024) <https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1849912273042854389>

Open USD, Variational, LayerZero Ch 14

T 1

PROVES the launch proves before it says; the list is the positioning; the coordination signal kills doubt.

SOURCE Ekram: the three linked launch reads (2026)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2071972042518512053>,
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2057142394831921634>,
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2021715757797978248>

Euler Ch 15

T 2

PROVES disclose first, own the history, and the crisis becomes the comeback's first chapter.

PUBLIC FACT the March 2023 hack (roughly \$197M), the public negotiation and recovery of funds, the relaunch under the same name.

SOURCE Ekram: "Euler keeping the same name is interesting. Sets them up for a comeback narrative. Respect." (2024)
<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1832155880575660160>

Celestia: the whole machine Ch 16

T 1

PROVES meaning, category, belief, inevitability, and delivery run as one system.

SOURCE Sources: all held in the chapters above; the machine passage is the arranger's synthesis.

General Magic Ch 2 · counter-case

T 2

PROVES a strong reality with no carryable story gets filed nowhere; "too early" is what a market calls a future nobody made legible.

PUBLIC FACT the Apple spin-out that shipped a pocket communicator in 1994, built by future creators of the iPod, Android, and eBay; it sold almost nothing and faded, and the same idea conquered the world in 2007 arriving as three already-understood words.

SOURCE The reading is entirely ours; Ekram's corpus does not reference General Magic, and Chapter 2's editor's note says so.

Source. Every quoted tweet is linked; edited transcript excerpts are labeled, not linked; public fact and Ekram's words are kept separate in each entry.

D. Lineage And Reading Map

The canon the method stands on, and where the walls are. Retweets and citations are treated as lineage signals, evidence of taste and influence, not proof that Ekram coined an idea. Ekram's own coinages are in Section E; the book's organizing frames are the editor's synthesis, not anyone's inheritance.

Al Ries & Jack Trout · Positioning

The foundation: positioning is a battle for the mind, not the market, and the Law of Sacrifice, that a position is defined by what you refuse.

WHAT EKRAM DOES He re-derives both under frontier conditions, where products fork and narrative leads product, and makes the cost the proof of a real position.

Chapters 1 & 4

Andy Cunningham · Ekram's mentor

Worked with Steve Jobs on the Macintosh launch. The rational-versus-emotional split, position first then brand, the rule that positioning must hurt, and the three modes of differentiation: product, concept, and user.

WHAT EKRAM DOES He carries it into crypto and AI and teaches the must-hurt edge as a live discipline, crediting her by name.

Chapters 3, 4 & 6

Peter Thiel · Competition is for losers

The create-do-not-compete idea.

WHAT EKRAM DOES He attaches the burden of education, the tax a category creator actually pays and most teams cannot.

Chapter 6

David Sacks

The two formulas Ekram quotes directly: the Jordan Way and the Thiel Way, with the middle as death.

WHAT EKRAM DOES He runs it through crypto markets, Solana as Jordan and Celestia as Thiel. A citation Ekram makes, not his coinage.

Chapter 6

Jeff Bezos

A brand is what people say about you when you are not in the room.

WHAT EKRAM DOES He builds his response-not-stimulus doctrine on top of it, credited to Bezos wherever it appears.

Chapters 3 & 9

Peter Drucker

"Culture eats strategy." Inherited, and it stays inherited: the phrase is Drucker's even though Ekram calls it his most repeated learning.

WHAT EKRAM DOES The application, culture as a positioning tool a strategy must be built to fit.

Chapter 10

René Girard · Mimetic desire

Cited repeatedly in Ekram's posts; the idea that desire is borrowed from others sits under the founder-as-symbol and status-triangulation material.

WHAT EKRAM DOES A lineage signal; the chapters use the mechanic without leaning on the name.

Chapter 11

E. Glossary Of Coinages

Every term the book uses, tagged by who owns it. Ekram phrase: appears in his verbatim tweets or blogs, or in labeled transcript. Inherited: belongs to the canon, credited to the source. Editor synthesis: the book's organizing language, not anyone's quote. Only terms the manuscript uses are listed. Ekram phrases

position, or be positioned (X, 2017; essay)

If you do not author your position, the market assigns you a lazy one.

Ch 1

every company exists twice (X, 2026)

A company exists as reality and as the story the market acts on.

Ch 2

you can't fork brand (X, 2024)

The product forks; the earned brand does not.

Ch 2

a great positioning strategy must hurt (X, 2026)

A real position costs something now, and the pain is the proof.

Ch 4

every "no" is a deeper "yes" (essay)

Each exclusion concentrates the audience that matters most.

Ch 4

the name is the thesis (X, 2026)

A strong name encodes the whole pitch before a feature is explained.

Ch 5

coordinating with rivals makes the category inevitable (X, 2026)

A category becomes real when rivals adopt its language.

Ch 7

make them feel historical (X, 2026)

Beat a competitor by making their worldview feel old, not by claiming you are better.

Ch 8

turn your case into a category question (X, 2026)

Reframe your specific moment as the question the whole category has to answer.

Ch 8

brand is a response, not a stimulus (essay; keynote)

Brand is the feeling a position earns, not the signal you send.

Ch 9

no-FUD (X, 2025)

The absence of attacks as the signature of irrelevance.

Ch 9

the founder is the lightning rod (X, 2025)

In early markets the founder is the compression point for the whole brand.

Ch 11

main character mode (X, 2024)

The founder runs point as a character, the marketing analogue to founder mode.

Ch 11

narrative is the frontline (X, 2024)

Narrative is where the attention war is actually fought.

Ch 12

narrative-market-fit (X, 2022)

Narrative traction can arrive before product-market-fit.

Ch 12, Ch 16

months are noise, years are truth (X, 2025)

Judge a narrative over years, not cycles.

Interlude III, Ch 12

create the crisis (X, 2023)

Name a danger and channel the alarm into market action.

Ch 13

the list is the positioning (X, 2026)

The coalition you assemble is itself the argument.

Ch 14

coordination signal (X, 2026)

A wall of credible backers announced together, to kill the will-this-survive doubt.

Ch 14

he or she who discloses first, wins (essay)

In a crisis, the first to disclose controls the frame.

Ch 15 **Inherited, credited to the source**

positioning, the battle for the mind (Ries and Trout)

Ch 1 and throughout

the Law of Sacrifice (Ries and Trout)

Ch 4

position first, then brand; rational versus emotional (Andy Cunningham)

Ch 3

product, concept, and user differentiation (Andy Cunningham)

Ch 6

the Jordan Way and the Thiel Way (David Sacks)

Ch 6

competition is for losers (Peter Thiel)

Ch 6

a brand is what people say when you are not in the room (Jeff Bezos)

Ch 3, Ch 9

culture eats strategy (Peter Drucker)

Ch 10 Editor synthesis, the book's language

legible, desirable, inevitable

The arc of what positioning has to achieve: understood, wanted, believed.

Front matter and throughout

the five movements: meaning, category, belief, inevitability, delivery

The book's spine.

Throughout

the second existence

The book's shorthand for Ekram's "every company exists twice."

Ch 2

the future-delta test

The book's name for his disappeared tomorrow question.

Ch 12

create, channel, defend

The book's frame for the attention chapter.

Ch 15

prove before you say

The book's launch method.

Ch 14

the straddle

The book's term for trying to compete and create at once; the "middle" it warns against is David Sacks'.

Ch 6

the positioning machine

The book's name for the whole method run as one system.

Ch 16

Source. Ekram phrases are drawn from his verbatim tweets and essays or labeled transcript. Inherited terms are credited to their originators. Editor synthesis terms are marked as such.

F. Toolkits

An operator's kit, organized by the decision you are facing. Working tools, not homework. Where a tool is the book's own procedure it is marked editor synthesis; where it rests on the keynote it is marked edited transcript. The doctrine behind each tool is sourced in the chapters and the quote bank.

When you are positioning

The four questions

EDITED TRANSCRIPT

- **What is it.** the noun a reporter would print with the marketing stripped out.
- **Why does it matter.** the value, not the feature; ask 'so what' until you hit something a human wants.
- **Why you, not a substitute.** the real alternative is usually the status quo.
- **Why now.** the trend that makes this the moment.

We are the [what] that [why it matters], for people who [who], unlike [the substitute], and now is the moment because [why now].

If a blank makes you reach for an adjective, you have not answered it. Two checks: the reporter test, strip every emotional word and see if a claim remains; the empty-room test, would your best customer say this sentence to a peer when you are not there.

When you are sacrificing

The cut list

EDITOR SYNTHESIS

- The one word or space you are trying to own.
- What you must stop claiming: every other thing your homepage says you are, cut to one.
- Who you are not for, named out loud.
- The no you keep dodging because it costs real money or a real segment.

If none of the four made you wince, cut deeper.

When you are choosing the game

Jordan or Thiel

EDITOR SYNTHESIS

- Say the word: compete or create, no straddle.
 - Name what you own: the axis you win on, or the category you define.
 - Name the comparison you accept or escape.
 - Price the bill: proof and defense for Jordan, education and patience for Thiel.
-

When you are naming

The four-way test

EDITOR SYNTHESIS

- Does the name or phrase explain, compress, provoke, or merely decorate.
- What future does the name tell the market to expect.
- Cut dead launch language, starting with "we're excited to announce."

When a competitor is winning**The frame flip**

EDITOR SYNTHESIS · CH 8

- Do not argue superiority; the market has to check arguments.
 - Name the old world, the new world, and why the leader cannot cross without betraying what made them.
 - Choose the enemy deliberately: a rival, the status quo, or the whole category.
 - Check the prize first: if the market is shrinking, decline the fight. If the attack is on you, turn your case into a category question.
-

When you are building the narrative**The future-delta**

EDITOR SYNTHESIS

- Write the future that recedes if the company disappears, in one sentence.
- Test consistency: one thing said many ways and held for years, or a story that resets every six months.

When nobody feels the urgency**The alarm check**

EDITOR SYNTHESIS · CH 13

- Name what happens if the market ignores the shift, in one sentence.
 - Put the deadline close enough to bite; a danger with no clock is an announcement.
 - Run the honesty test: alarm makes a real, near-term downside visible, hype inflates a reward that may never arrive.
 - When the shift is real, frame the binary so inaction feels like choosing the bad branch.
-

When you are launching**Launch proof**

EDITOR SYNTHESIS

- Decide what the launch must prove before what it says: inevitability, momentum, a coalition, a direction.
 - Stage the proof so the market reads it first.
 - Check the timing: do not ship into a bigger story.
-

When the story turns**The crisis page**

EDITOR SYNTHESIS

- Write it before you need it.
- Disclose first, fast, and full.
- Acknowledge plainly, no euphemism.
- Reframe around the pivot-point: shift attention from the accusation to the answer rather than going silent.
- Name who reviews the response before it posts.

When you are setting the founder signal and the team

Founder & team

EDITOR SYNTHESIS

- **Founder.** name the authentic edge and the one visible, costly risk taken in public; name the people who echo the founder; decide on purpose whether the brand wears a face.
- **Team.** hire in-house before an agency, someone who lives and breathes the brand
(<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1844835648530002096>); bet on one high-taste creative rather than committee output
(<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/1903167129559409075>); look for a working cringe detector, high IQ and high EQ, terminally online
(<https://x.com/ekrahm/status/2034452926954115440>).

Source. Every tool's doctrine is sourced in the chapters and the quote bank. The procedures and templates are editor synthesis, labeled. The four questions are from the keynote (edited transcript), inherited from Cunningham.

Colophon

The Ekram Method, an independent reconstruction of Ekram's public work, arranged by Somo. The method is his; the selection, arrangement, and connective writing are the arranger's. Quotes are drawn from his tweets, essays, and talks, and checked against a verbatim source bank; the gray bands throughout carry only his words.

Linked Resources



SOMO ON X

The arranger.

<https://x.com/somonaat>



EKRAM ON X

The source.

<https://x.com/ekrahm>



EKRAMMETHOD.COM

The book online.

<https://ekrammethod.com/>